

Exclusive: Costa's budget fix

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Presented by Google By NICHOLAS VINOCUR with GREGORIO SORGI GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Lots to cover today — let's dive in. START HERE: EU foreign

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Lots to cover today — let's dive in.

START HERE: EU foreign ministers meeting on the sidelines of the U.N. General Assembly (UNGA) in New York today will try to get to grips with what to do if a Russian hybrid attack kills EU or NATO citizens — a possibility that experts warn is increasingly likely, two EU diplomats told Playbook.

Russian roulette: "Given the scope and shape of Russia's action there are bound to be casualties sooner or later," said one of the diplomats. "It's sheer luck there haven't been any yet." Warnings of hybrid attacks have sparked a flurry of EU diplomacy, with one senior EU diplomat telling Playbook that envoys will meet this week in the Council's secure meeting room, aka the "bunker," to discuss the danger.

GERMANY'S FAR RIGHT WINS AGAIN: The Alternative for Germany won an election in the northeastern state of Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania, though it will be prevented from governing due to a strong second-place finish by the Social Democratic Party. Friedrich Merz called the result a "disaster" — but has vowed to stay on as chancellor. Merz's CDU also lost support in a separate regional vote in Berlin won by the far-left party. My colleagues in Germany have the latest .

JOIN US: Tomorrow's Brussels Playbook Live lineup is set, and it's not too late to sign up. On the bill are U.S. Ambassador to the EU Andrew Puzder; Canada's Ambassador-designate to the EU Jonathan Wilkinson; France's European Affairs Minister Benjamin Haddad; Ukraine's Deputy Prime Minister Vsevolod Chentsov; Poland's Secretary of State for Foreign Affairs Ignacy Niemczycki; and MEPs René Repasi, Mika Aaltola and Gerben-Jan Gerbrandy. Plus, your favorite authors and podcast hosts ... Click here for more details and to register to watch live.

In today's Playbook:

— Scoop: 11 countries are calling for a time-out on new EU laws.

— All eyes are on France this morning as Russia sanctions talks come down to the wire.

— Faces in the crowd: António Costa, Claudia Bauer, Ursula von der Leyen, Kaja Kallas, Roxana Mînzatu, Nadia Calviño, Friedrich Merz, Micheál Martin and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Nick unpack why Merz's bid to stop the far right is failing spectacularly.

****A message from Google:** Today we open Connected Cup, an AI pop-up by Google. A temporary coffee and events space in the Brussels EU Quarter, open to everyone from 21 September to 16 October, weekdays 08:00 to 16:00, with a coffee area, product demos and events. Explore the programme .**

DRIVING THE DAY

EXCLUSIVE — COSTA'S ART OF THE DEAL: European Council President António Costa told Playbook that any plan to cut the EU's next seven-year budget risks running into opposition from national governments.

"It's easier to say 'I want to reduce the global volume' but it's much more difficult to reach a consensus to cut on the different policies funded by the budget," Costa told Gregorio Sorigi.

Over the past month, the Council president visited the leaders of most EU countries — he's due to visit Stockholm and The Hague in the coming weeks — to sound them out on the most sensitive issues in the negotiations. In an interview with Playbook, Costa laid out for the first time what the leaders told him.

Playbook joined Costa on a packed (and late) Ryanair flight to Dublin last week. At the leafy Farmleigh House, an official country residence, Costa compared notes with Irish Taoiseach Micheál Martin, whose country holds the rotating presidency of the Council of the EU and will put forward a budget negotiating document, the "negobox," early next month.

Although German Chancellor Friedrich Merz and four other leaders called for cuts of several hundred billion euros in an op-ed on POLITICO last week, Costa said he sensed little appetite from most leaders to downsize specific pots of money in the budget. "I ask, 'Who wants to cut on defense?' No one. 'Who wants to cut on competitiveness?' No one. 'Who wants to cut on agriculture?' No one."

"Everybody agrees that we can cut on [EU] administrative expenditure but it's a very small amount [and] it doesn't solve the problem," Costa said. (It makes up only 6% of the total budget.) There's greater appetite from governments to cut foreign aid, worth €200 billion for the next seven years, an EU official with knowledge of the negotiations said.

Costa believes that introducing new EU-wide taxes, or own resources, is key to averting major cuts and keeping national contributions to Brussels stable. New own resources are more likely to be approved if they generate fresh revenue that is not already collected by national governments, he said.

Costa pointed to a proposed EU tobacco tax, which governments have criticized because it taps revenue already collected by capitals. But he said newer products such as vapes and e-cigarettes are not taxed in many countries. Focusing on these products can generate "new money," he said. "Then it means it's easier [to secure an agreement.]"

BIG AND BREAKING

THIS WEEK IN NEW YORK: A host of top EU officials and national leaders are attending UNGA, including Commission President Ursula von der Leyen, Costa, High Representative Kaja Kallas, European Parliament President Roberta Metsola, and Commission Executive Vice Presidents Teresa Ribera and Roxana Mînzatu.

THE CARNEY-VAL CONTINUES: Costa told Gregorio the EU can do more with Canada on defense, AI and strengthening democracy ... and European Investment Bank President Nadia Calviño will meet Canadian PM Mark Carney in New York this week, my colleague Kathryn Carlson reports (for subscribers) .

STILL IN CONTROL: Russia's ruling United Russia party was last night on track to easily win a tightly controlled parliamentary election, the Associated Press reports , after Ukraine launched a massive drone attack on Moscow over the weekend.

Meanwhile in Kyiv: Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy posted on X that he'll meet Donald Trump in New York this week, hinting that "this meeting could change a lot."

Secret drone plan: Moscow is ramping up its capacity to make the killer drones it deploys in attacks on Ukrainian cities, according to plans from a Russian state company obtained by POLITICO.

TIGHTENING THE SCREWS: The Trump administration is stepping up its campaign against the International Criminal Court, preparing sweeping sanctions that would effectively cut it off from the global financial system, the Wall Street Journal reports . Reuters hears similar .

RED TAPE WARNING

EXCLUSIVE — VIENNA HITS PAUSE: Austria is leading a push with 10 other countries to pause new EU legislation for 12 months for what the country's Europe Minister Claudia Bauer describes as a "year of simplification."

Roll up your sleeves: "We can't go on tabling new legislative proposals when existing rules have not been fully implemented," Bauer said in an interview with Playbook, referring to a discussion paper signed by Austria, Germany, Italy, Poland, Denmark, the Czech Republic, Slovakia, Slovenia, Lithuania, Portugal and Hungary and seen by POLITICO.

Brussels is already scrambling to roll out red-tape-cutting packages known as "omnibuses" — but those efforts don't go far enough, according to Bauer.

"What we are doing now is mostly ex-post simplification," she said. "We fully support the Commission's omnibus packages but it cannot become the standard that we have new legislation and then a whole string of other acts to simplify it. Simplification should start before legislation is adopted."

The signatories want any proposed laws from Brussels to undergo a rigorous assessment to determine its suitability and whether it supports the wider aim of bolstering economic competitiveness. All new regulations would be subject to an impact review every five years.

The key demand: Brussels must devote an entire year to stocktaking of current laws and implement what's already there. "Such an effort should not be viewed as deregulation, but as an exercise in

legislative deep-cleaning,” a draft of the discussion paper reads. “To quote Elvis Presley, we need a little less conversation and a little more action,” added Bauer.

Several of the signatories also favor severely limiting the EU’s operating costs — something that might fit well with cutting back on laws.

The bottom line: Advocates of slashing red tape are sharpening their rhetoric and sending a warning to the Commission: Cut back on regulations and directives ASAP — or else.

****This week, Playbook is leaving your inbox and taking the stage, twice. Join us online for Brussels Playbook Live, where our authors and podcast hosts will unpack the power plays, policy battles and political personalities shaping Europe’s capital. Then, in Playbook Paris Live, the focus turns to France’s 2027 presidential race: the candidates, the campaign strategies, the key issues, and the people working behind the scenes to shape what comes next. Two cities, two Playbooks and plenty to discuss. Watch Brussels Playbook Live [here](#) and Playbook Paris Live [here](#) .****

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

Germany’s chief of defense, Carsten Breuer, was voted in as the chair of NATO’s highest military authority. But what is that authority and what does it do? As chair of the NATO military committee, Breuer will be expected to give honest military advice to allies — helping assess the feasibility, financing and capabilities of operations. He will also oversee dozens of working groups of NATO military staff, and broker consensus on formulating military advice.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked for your ideas to save or make money for the EU budget. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

RUSSIA SANCTIONS

NOW OR NEVER: France’s actions this morning will determine whether one of the EU’s sanctions programs against Russia falls apart.

EU ambassadors will gather from 9 a.m. If they don’t extend sanctions on some 3,000 Russia-linked companies and individuals, the current batch will expire at midnight Tuesday. After France and Slovakia sought to remove prominent individuals from the list, this is the final chance for capitals to agree, three diplomats told Playbook.

“Ultimately, it’s up to the French: will they let the entire sanctions regime collapse?” said one of the diplomats, granted anonymity to discuss closed-door talks.

France stunned other EU countries by seeking to lift sanctions targeting Russian-Uzbek billionaire Alisher Usmanov, because of concerns about a French citizen detained in Azerbaijan, just as Europe is growing increasingly worried about Russia. France’s own President Emmanuel Macron is among those sounding the alarm about the security threat , announcing plans Friday to protect critical infrastructure against a potential attack.

Attempts to negotiate a compromise last week failed, despite countries agreeing to extend the expiration deadline, the diplomats said.

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

THE COMPANY TRUMP CAN'T IGNORE: POLITICO Magazine has a must-click story on the complicated rise of Anthropic and how its new Mythos model changed Washington's approach to artificial intelligence.

GREENLAND DEAL: The U.S., Greenland and Denmark will ink a deal at UNGA on "strengthened security in the Arctic and North Atlantic Area," per a Danish statement .

WHY THE RIGHT FAILED IN SWEDEN: The Sweden Democrats' disappointing performance in last week's Swedish election goes against the recent trend. Tim Ross has more on the lessons learned .

VEIL BAN: Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni said her government is preparing two legislative proposals that would ban face coverings in Italian schools and restrict the number of foreign students allowed in classrooms.

DIPLOMATIC CLASH: France will summon Iran's ambassador after Iranian authorities sealed a French language center affiliated with its embassy in Tehran, Reuters reported overnight .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny intervals. High 19C.

BRUSSELS CLEANS UP ITS ACT: To coincide with World Cleanup Week, Brussels' Sewer Museum and City to Ocean are organizing a walk along the canal today, during which participants will clean up litter and feed pics of the trash into AI to figure out what's ending up in Brussels' waterways.

PSL TIME: It's fall, which means it's officially pumpkin spice latte season for those who celebrate, Sebastian Starcevic writes. Where can you find the cozy brew in Brussels? Café Léopold makes a mean iced PSL with Chantilly cream. Nine Coffee, Mio Coffee, Lloyd Coffee Eatery and Cup 28 all advertise it on their menus (some seasonally, so go while you can). Café du Sablon does a honey cinnamon latte, for a similarly autumnal beverage.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: The CDU and SPD are weighing their next moves after another bruising election result.

Paris: Emmanuel Macron will use a joint prime-time interview with two TV networks Thursday to amplify his warning about the grave threats facing France.

London: Westminster's political leaders are scattered around the country today while Andy Burnham heads to New York for UNGA.

Washington: The cost of living is voters' biggest concern ahead of the midterms — but the parties have sharply different ideas about how to tackle it.

Ottawa: Parliament is back in session , but Mark Carney is only in town for a hot minute before flying to New York.

Canberra: Anthony Albanese will meet Ursula von der Leyen and António Costa in New York — though he won't be pushing associate EU membership for Australia.

****Playbook is coming to Madrid. Read up on the people, power moves and insider intelligence shaping Spanish politics, delivered every morning in Spanish. Sign up for Madrid Playbook. ****

AGENDA

— Various European Commissioners and EU leaders are in New York for this week's U.N. General Assembly meeting.

— Partners for multilateralism, international law, peace and prosperity summit on the margins of UNGA, hosted by European Council President António Costa with Kenyan President William Ruto and Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney. Commission President Ursula von der Leyen will deliver a speech. Press conference around 7:45 p.m. local time (1:45 a.m. Tuesday in Brussels).

— Von der Leyen and Costa meet Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese.

— EU foreign ministers meet on the sidelines of UNGA.

— EU High Representative Kaja Kallas will co-host a ministerial-level side event on humanitarian law and action, with Preparedness and Crisis Management Commissioner Hadja Lahbib and representatives from Ireland, Jordan, Canada, Brazil and the African Union.

— Kallas will also attend an informal meeting of G7 foreign ministers.

— European Parliament President Roberta Metsola is also in New York, where she participates in a Friends of the Western Balkans meeting hosted by Italian Foreign Minister Antonio Tajani; meets Malta's Foreign Minister Chris Fearne; and participates in a conversation on "Leading Europe Forward" at the Foreign Policy Magazine Summit at 9:30 p.m. Watch live .

— Informal meeting of EU transport ministers in Dublin, with Sustainable Transport Commissioner Apostolos Tzitzikostas attending.

— Commission Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto is in Hungary, where he meets Finance Minister András Kármán, Rural Development Minister Viktória Lőrincz and Budapest Mayor Gergely Karácsony.

— Sport Commissioner Glenn Micallef meets representatives of FIFPRO and UEFA.

— Financial Services Commissioner Maria Luís Albuquerque participates in a roundtable with BusinessEurope and associated industrial organizations.

BIRTHDAYS

MEPs Carlo Fidanza; former MEPs Vicky Ford and Jan Olbrycht; Latvian President Edgars Rinkēvičs; Energy Infrastructure Partners' Zeke Turner; journalist Laurel Henning; Akamai Technologies' Christian Borggreen; Deutsche Bank's Patricia Summers Edwards; Stephan Schraff from Bayer; Harvard professor and former USAID Administrator Samantha Power; POLITICO's Tommaso Lecca; former Australian PM and former Ambassador to the U.S. Kevin Rudd; EISMEA's Robert Schröder; Malta's Independence Day.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from Google:** Europe's future is shaped in Brussels, and more often than not, it all starts with a cup of coffee. As AI becomes a bigger part of these conversations, how is AI made and used in Europe today? How can those policies best align with practical, everyday AI experiences? Join us at Connected Cup , an AI pop-up by Google, for hands-on demos, engaging workshops, and inspiring conversations with Europe's foremost innovators on artificial intelligence. The goal is to ground complex discussions in reality with tangible product experiences: a shared coffee space where anyone can come and see how AI works in Europe, ask questions, and connect with the people building it. Open to everyone at Rue d'Arlon, 80, from 21 September to 16 October, weekdays 08:00 to 16:00, with product demos and events. Explore the programme , or just drop by. Come for the technology; stay for the coffee!**

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